

The Tell: Which Pitch-Sequencing Giveaways Survive New Games, and Whether Hitters Cash In

Introduction. Advance scouts sell sequencing tells (“after a slider he doubles up”), and clubs act on them in hitter meetings. No public method separates a real tell from one found by searching hundreds of pitchers, counts and previous pitches. We ask how much the previous pitch gives away beyond count and batter hand, how much of a scouted tell survives into new games, whether hitters punish it, and whether the 2026 automated ball-strike (ABS) system changed it.

Methods. We use all 2,049,352 regular-season Statcast pitches from 2024–2026 (1,793 pitcher-seasons with 250+ pitches). For each pitcher-season, nested models predict pitch type from batter hand, then count, then the previous pitch, scored on games they never saw. The gain from the previous pitch is TELL. A cue is the count, hand and previous pitch that most shifts one pitch type’s share. We find each pitcher’s top cue in April–June (or 2025) and score it only on later games. Whiff and run-value regressions hold pitcher-season, pitch type and count fixed. An in-season alarm multiplies permutation e-values game by game. ABS is tested on paired pitchers against a 2024–25 placebo.

Results.

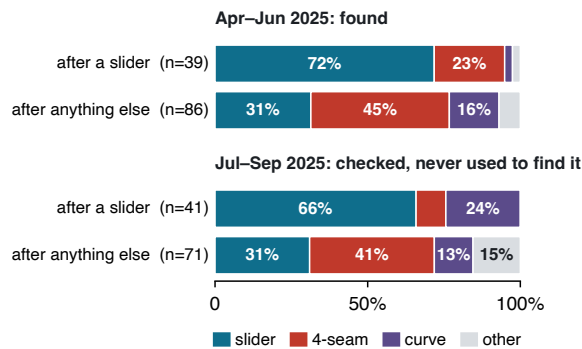
- Added in that order, batter hand and count carry 102 and 58 millibits about the next pitch; the previous pitch adds 8.1. A hitter guessing the likeliest pitch gains 0.6 points of accuracy on average, and 5 against Dylan Cease.
- Selection inflates tells. The top April–June cue shifts the next pitch by 26 points when found and 10 points on July–September games, in the same direction 78% of the time (no tell: 0 points, 50%; Figure 1B). Across seasons, 28 points becomes 13.
- The ten largest 2025 cues with enough 2026 data all kept their direction (Table 1).
- TELL is reliable within a season (odd versus even games, 0.73) but not across seasons ($r = 0.19$, versus 0.62 for count usage).
- Predictable pitches are not punished. From the 10th to the 90th percentile of predictability, whiffs rise 0.6 points ($t = 4.7$) and run value improves 0.23 runs per 100 pitches ($t = 5.3$; Figure 1C).
- The alarm fired for 24% of 2025 pitchers, at a median of 290 pitches (Figure 1D).
- ABS lowered the top of the called zone by 1.2 inches (placebo 0.2) but moved TELL by -0.04 millibits (95% CI -1.47 to $+1.39$). The zone moved; sequencing did not.

Conclusion. Sequencing tells are real, season-specific, and less than half as large in new games as when found. Scouts should discount them accordingly. Hitters show no sign of exploiting them. The alarm gives clubs an in-season flag with a guaranteed false-alarm rate. Code: github.com/aidaneichman/the-tell.

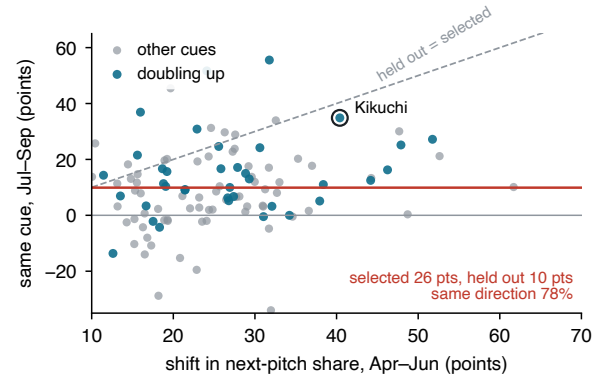
Table 1. Largest 2025 cues (50+ pitches; 25+ in 2026). Next-pitch share after the cue versus otherwise (%).

Pitcher	Situation	Next pitch	2025	2026
Dylan Lee	0-1 vs RHB, after slider	slider	75 vs 9	69 vs 25
Jack Leiter	1-2 vs LHB, after 4-seam	4-seam	22 vs 68	33 vs 50
Kevin Gausman	0-2 vs LHB, after 4-seam	4-seam	60 vs 15	51 vs 26
Chris Sale	0-1 vs RHB, after slider	4-seam	22 vs 66	30 vs 55
Gregory Soto	0-1 vs RHB, after sinker	sinker	62 vs 19	46 vs 24
Matthew Boyd	2-2 vs RHB, after change	4-seam	71 vs 30	56 vs 28
Hunter Brown	0-1 vs RHB, after sinker	sinker	62 vs 22	64 vs 28
Kris Bubic	1-0 vs RHB, after 4-seam	4-seam	54 vs 16	67 vs 24
Drew Rasmussen	1-2 vs LHB, after cutter	cutter	7 vs 45	4 vs 30
Dustin May	1-2 vs LHB, after sweeper	sweeper	31 vs 68	19 vs 42

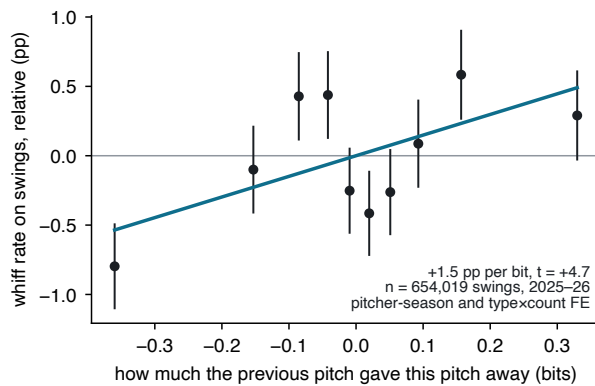
A One cue: Yusei Kikuchi, 1-0 count, right-handed batter



B Each pitcher's top cue, re-scored on new games (n = 110)



C Predictable pitches are not punished



D An in-season alarm with a false-alarm guarantee

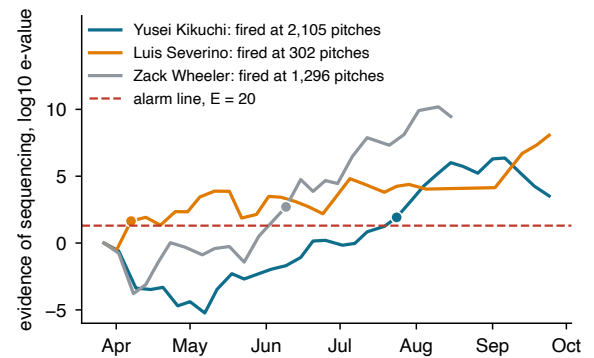


Figure 1. (B) Cues with 30+ pitches each way. (C) Deciles, 95% intervals. (D) Dots: alarm fired.